

Why film form is important in film studies or the film culture?

Form as pattern

Formal expectations

Conventions and experience

Form and feeling

Form and meaning (Like emotion, meaning is important to our experience of artwork).

For neoformalists, such as Bordwell and Thompson

Meaning is constructed out of textual cues, not created out of thin air; nor is it the result of isolated individuals creating unique and unprecedented interpretations within a social vacuum:

interpretation is a psychological and social activity that takes place within particular institutions according to social conventions.

# Principles of Film Form

Form does not equal formula. Scientists discover powerful laws governing the physical world, but in the arts there are no laws of form that all artists must follow. Artists create within culture, so many principles of artistic form are matters of convention.

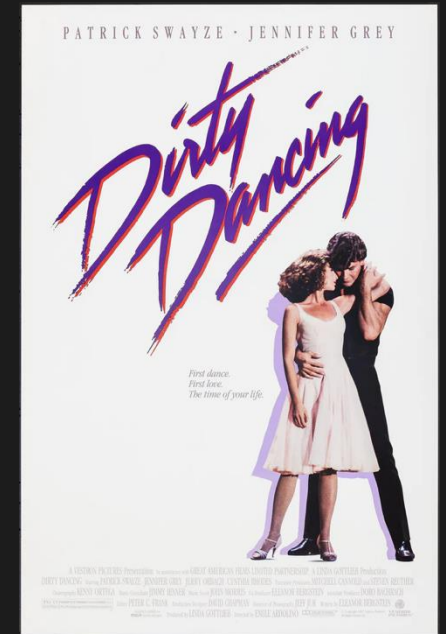
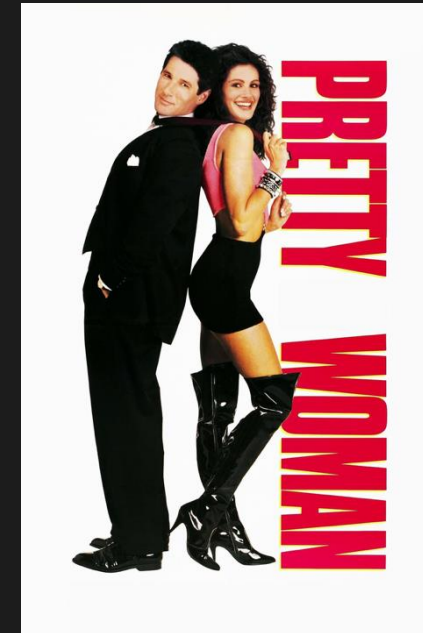
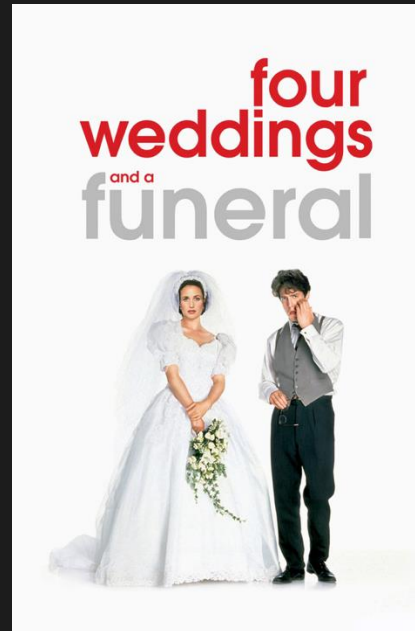
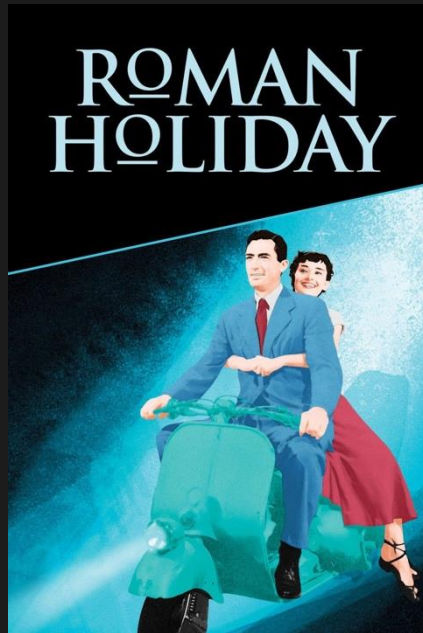
“Film form is a system – a unified set of related but independent elements – there must be some principles that help created the relationship among the parts”

- Bordwell and Thomson

# Difference and Variation

certain parts might repeat with variation, the variation could be slight or substantial.

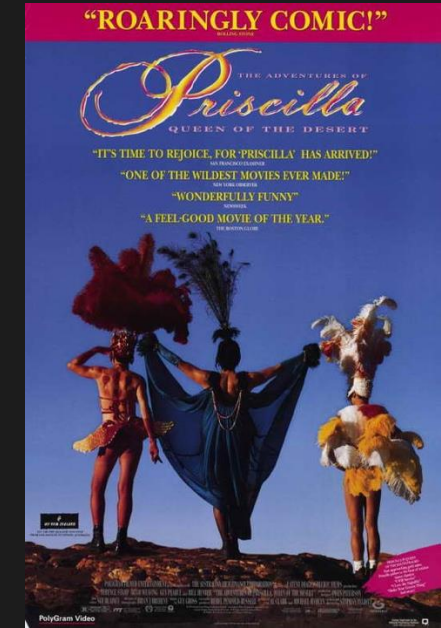
We will burrow deep into this part on *Week 13*.



# Developments

One way to notice how similarity and difference operate in film form is to look for principles of development from part to part.

Filmmakers often treat formal development as a progression moving from beginning through middle to end.



## Analytic

1. Cognitive film theory
2. Historical poetics
3. Linguistic film theory
4. Neoformalism (David Borwell, Kristin Thompson)
5. Radical formalism (affect theory, Eugenie Brinkema)

## Classical Film Theories (Realism and Formalism, the ontology of cinema)

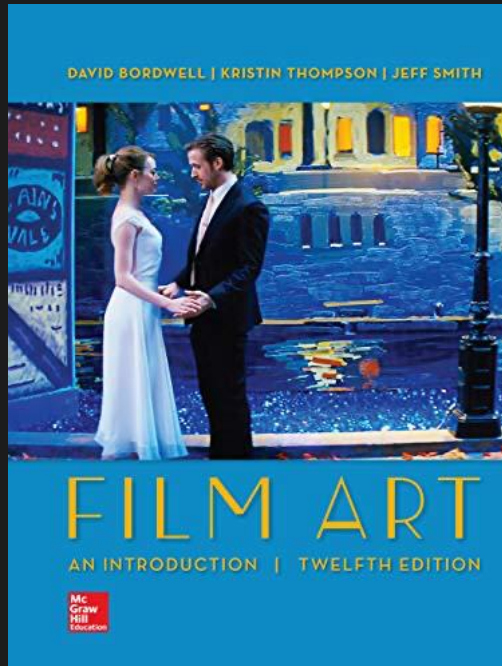
## Continental (Grand Film Theories, brings in Critical Theories, also Contemporary Film Theories)

1. Feminist film theory
2. Film semiotics
3. Marxist film theory
4. Psychoanalytic film theory
5. Screen theory
6. Structuralist film theory

## Criticism

Auteur theory





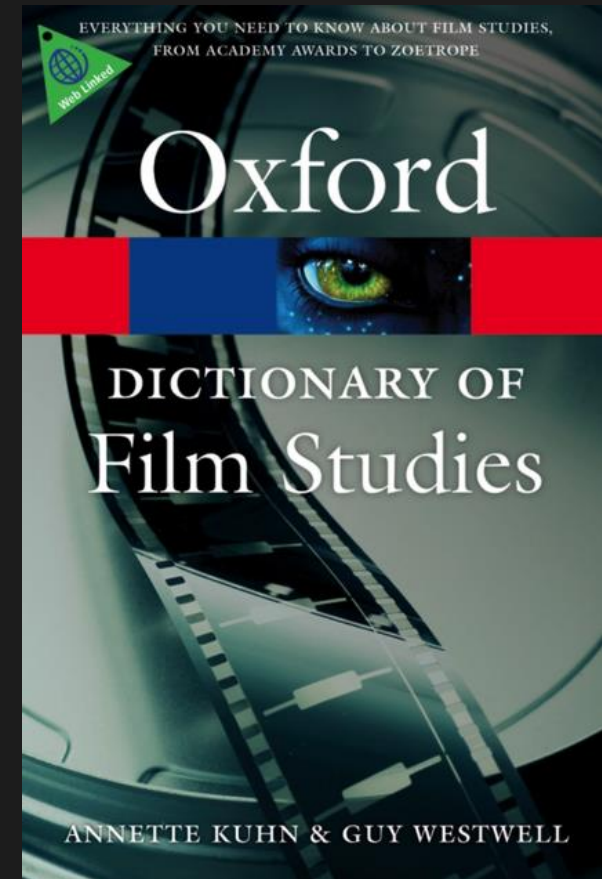
1979/ 2019

## neoformalism

An approach to the analysis of films deriving from **\*Russian Formalism**, and part of the **\*post-theory** movement in film studies. **Neoformalism** concerns itself with a film's narrative and stylistic form, the historical context of a film's form, and the activity of the viewer in making sense of films. Rather than imposing a prior theoretical approach, it takes films and the issues they raise as a starting point for study, contending that meanings in any film emerge through its unique deployment and combination of **devices** (which can embrace anything from plot to camerawork to costume). In any film, devices derive their meaning through their relation to each other, and this relationship is historically situated. Furthermore, perception, emotion, and cognition on the viewer's part are regarded by neoformalists as central in the functioning of a film's formal qualities.

## Russian Formalism

A school of literary theory that flourished in the Soviet Union in the decade after the 1917 revolution and subsequently in Czechoslovakia. Its concern is to identify the distinctive qualities of literary, as opposed to ordinary, language and to delineate the formal and technical aspects of literature—or *devices*—through which ‘literariness’ is achieved: these include defamiliarization (*ostranenie*, or making strange). Russian Formalism has had an important influence in \*semiotics, \*neoformalism, \*structuralism, and other branches of film theory devoted to uncovering the ‘filmness’ of film, or what makes a film a film and nothing else (see MEDIUM SPECIFICITY). It is not to be confused with formalism (with a small f), which refers to the attention to artistic technique at the expense of subject matter, either in filmmaking or in film criticism and theory.





A scene is a very small part of a movie that is composed of several shots.

A sequence is a comparatively larger part of the movie that is made up of several scenes.

Many sequences make up a complete film.

Research Method: not just watching films.

**Shot segmentation -> Sequence Analysis -> formal analysis -> textual analysis (close reading) with theories**

A **segmentation** is simply a written outline of the film that breaks it into its major and minor parts, with the part marked by numbers or letters. Segmenting a film enables us not only to notice similarities and differences among parts but also to plot the overall development.

In similar ways, a film coaxes us to connect **sequences** into a larger whole.

Formal analysis: assumes an active perceiver and a work of art that provides cues

To start your analysis:

shot, scene, sequence, part (structure of the film), and the whole filmic text

- Compare elements from different moments of the film
- Look at the way of a single element gets repeated
- Segmentation

“A boy rides his tricycle through an empty hotel”



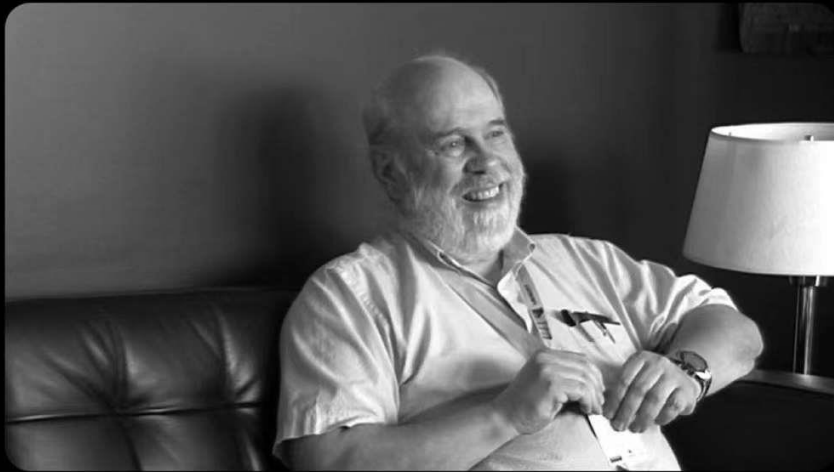


The Film Stage 🎬  
@TheFilmStage

RIP the legendary David Bordwell, who has died at 76.

His blog is one of the greatest resources on film criticism, analysis, and history:

[davidbordwell.net/blog/](https://davidbordwell.net/blog/)



18:52 · 2024/3/1 From Earth · **178K** Views

**378** Reposts **289** Quotes

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For several generations of film students, you read Bordwell's "Film Art: An Introduction" in your fall freshman Film 101 class.

Together, Bordwell and Thompson kept film studies graduates enthralled well after the conclusion of their studies by publishing an authoritative blog at davidbordwell.net and contributing a series of video essays to the Criterion Channel titled "Observations on Film Art."

Bordwell's research program consisted of three principal strands.

1. The first is composed of stylistic analyses of individual films or directors, most notably *The Films of Carl-Theodor Dreyer* (1980), the monumental *Ozu and the Poetics of Cinema* (1988), *The Cinema of Eisenstein* (1993), and detailed essays on Louis Feuillade, Kenji Mizoguchi, Theodoros Angelopoulos and Hou Hsiao-Hsien grouped in the volume *Figures Traced in Light: On Cinematic Staging* (2005). The introductory college textbook *Film Art: An Introduction*, written with Thompson, also contributes to this strand. First published in 1979, it is now in its thirteenth edition and will continue under the authorship of Professor Jeff Smith (UW-Madison). It has been translated into ten other languages, with additional translations forthcoming.

<https://commarts.wisc.edu/2024/03/remembering-professor-emeritus-david-bordwell/>



The analysis of national film styles and modes of film production constitutes the second strand of Bordwell's research. These studies incorporate primary-level documentary research on the structure of film industries, film technology, and the conditions of production. The most important work in this category is *The Classical Hollywood Cinema: Film Style and Mode of Production to 1960* (1985), written with Thompson and Janet Staiger (William P. Hobby Centennial Professor Emerita, University of Texas at Austin). A massive research undertaking, it incorporates stylistic analyses of a random sample of one hundred films, interviews with veteran cinematographers and other craft workers, and careful reading of film industry trade papers and industry technical reports.

The third strand of Bordwell's research involved theorizing the role of the film spectator in the movie-viewing experience. Bordwell's ground-breaking *Narration in the Fiction Film* (1985) proposed the idea that viewers integrated perceptual information with higher order cognition to construct the film's story. For Bordwell, spectators were active makers of meaning who drew on their understanding of cinematic conventions, their knowledge of different types of stories, and their real-life experience to comprehend the various visual and audio cues given to them by the film.

With this and several subsequent publications, Bordwell helped encourage a robust line of scholarship in cognitive film studies, an approach that brought together analytic philosophers and psychologists in developing a model of spectatorship that amalgamates aspects of art, culture, and even biology.

# Unpacking “Narrative” in Cinema

Week 3



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Assistant Professor in Film Studies

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So, in this week, we need to quibble over a set of related terms:

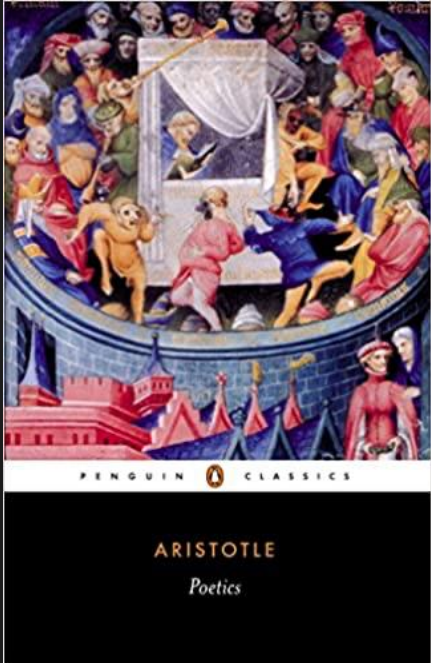
Story, plot, narrative, narration, narrator, perspective, POV,

The character arc, story arc.

### **Weekly topic intro:**

The course content for this week is a little bit brain-consuming. We need to deal with film narrative and understand its difference with “plot” and “story”. Narrative is a powerful element of human culture, storing and sharing the cherished parts of our personal memories and giving structure to our laws, entertainment, and history. We experience narrative in words, pictures, and film, yet regardless of how the tale is told, story remains independent from the media that makes it concrete. For film studies, we should consider a narrative to be a chain of events linked by cause and effect and occurring in time and space. After this, we move on to talk about “point of view”.

# Story:



Aristotle's *Poetics* is the earliest surviving work of Greek dramatic theory and first extant philosophical treatise to focus on literary theory.

Every story is different. Every writer is different. As a result, there is no secret formula, no single paradigm that is guaranteed to work. However, there is an approach which has had an enduring presence in the realm of screenwriting for many decades: **Three Act Structure**.

In *Poetics*, Aristotle wrote “A whole [story] is what has a beginning and middle and end.” His articulation of each of these three parts and how they fit together is as follows:

“A beginning is that which is not itself necessarily after anything else, and which has naturally something else after it. An end is that which is naturally after something itself, either as its necessary or usual consequent, and with nothing else after it. And a middle, that which is by nature after one thing and has also another after it.”

Beginning. Middle. End. Three parts. Three movements

For Aristotle, this is not a rigid structure but a **principle of narrative coherence**.

He explains it in terms of **causality**:

**Beginning** – something that does not necessarily follow from previous events but initiates action.

**Middle** – something that follows from the beginning and leads toward the outcome.

**End** – something that logically follows from previous events and resolves the action.

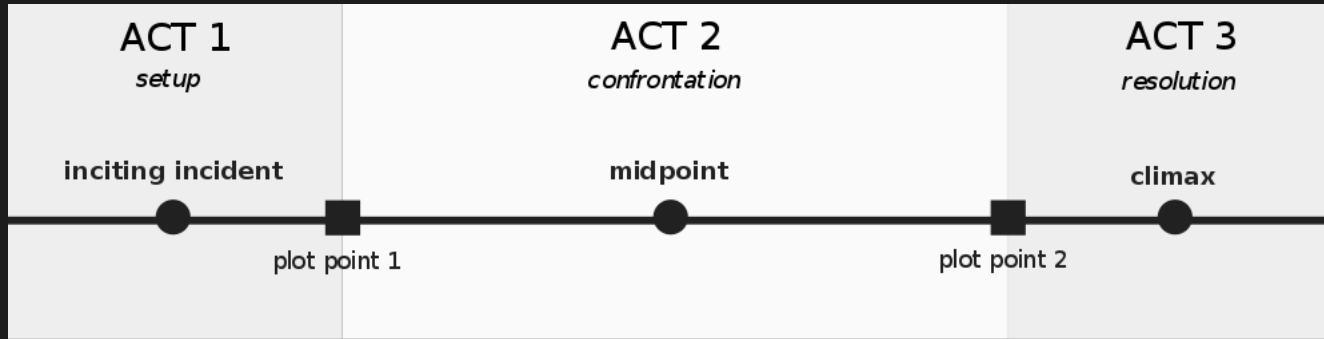
The crucial point is that Aristotle is concerned with **causal completeness**, not with a mechanical structure.

The relationship between the three-act structure and Aristotle's idea of beginning-middle-end is historical and conceptual, but they are not identical theories.

The three-act model can be understood as a modern codification of Aristotle's more general principle of dramatic unity, developed through later dramaturgy and screenwriting practice.

**THEY ARE NOT THE "SAME THING".**





It was popularized by Syd Field in his 1979 book *Screenplay: The Foundations of Screenwriting*.

In modern cinema and screenwriting, the three-act structure became a simplified version of this dramatic logic.

The **three-act structure** is the most widely recognised narrative template in mainstream Hollywood storytelling. Although it is often associated with screenwriting manuals (such as Syd Field), it corresponds closely to what David Bordwell calls the classical Hollywood narrative system, where actions are organised around goal-oriented characters and clear causal development.

## Act I: Setup

The first act introduces the story world, major characters, and the central conflict. It establishes **the initial equilibrium** and then introduces a disruptive event that launches the narrative action.

Typical elements include: exposition of characters and setting, introduction of the protagonist's goals, and the inciting incident that sets the story in motion

### Example:

In *Jurassic Park* (1993), the first act introduces the park, the scientists, and the ethical dilemma surrounding genetic engineering. The inciting incident is the decision to visit the island and evaluate the park.

## Act II: Confrontation / Development

The second act forms **the longest section** of the narrative. Here the protagonist encounters obstacles while pursuing a goal.

Key features include: escalating conflicts, complications and reversals, a midpoint turning point, and increasing stakes

Example:

In *The Matrix* (1999), the second act follows Neo's training, his discovery of the true nature of the Matrix, and the growing conflict with the agents.

### Act III: Resolution

The final act resolves the narrative conflict through a **climax** followed by a **new equilibrium**.

Typical elements: decisive confrontation (action film particularly, meet the final boss), revelation or solution (in detective film, find the murder), restoration or transformation of order (in sci-fi films, the world back to normal).

Example:

In *The Matrix*, the climax occurs when Neo accepts his role as “The One” and defeats Agent Smith.

In screenwriting manuals, Hollywood storytelling is often described through the three-act structure. 在 Bordwell 的 film studies 语境里，他其实不太强调“三幕结构”

However, film scholars such as David Bordwell prefer to describe it more broadly as **classical Hollywood narrative form**, characterised by goal-oriented characters, causal logic, and narrative closure.

## Bordwell and Thompson's definition of story

**The story** is the chain of events in chronological order.

But as we've seen, that story may be presented in various ways. If we use flashbacks instead of linear time, or if we decide to organize events around one character rather than another, or if we make other choices about presentation, we will be **creating a different plot**.

As we've just seen, the same story can be presented in different ways—rendered as different plots—and each variant is likely to have different effects on the audience.

# For spectators:

**Story** includes not only the on-screen/depicted events depicted by the filmmaker, but also the “inferred” or “suggested” events that we might not actually see.

The story includes:  
events shown in the film  
events inferred by the viewer

**A plot** is generally understood to mean events as they happen on screen.

1. Linear: time moves in a straight line from beginning to middle to end
2. Non-Linear: time is presented in a disjointed way – for example the director might use “flashback” or “flashforward” to show the audience past or future events

**Plot** refers to: the arrangement of events as they are presented in the film.

Do the characters in the film see or hear what I see or hear?



yes,  
so  
diegetic

no,  
so  
Non-diegetic

**diegesis = recounted story (story world)**

The diegesis refers to:  
the total world of the story action.



- characters
- locations
- sounds within the story world
- film score
- credits
- titles

**Story**      The full chronological chain of events

**Plot**      The events as organised and presented in the film

So, now we know that:

Filmmakers construct the plot from the story.

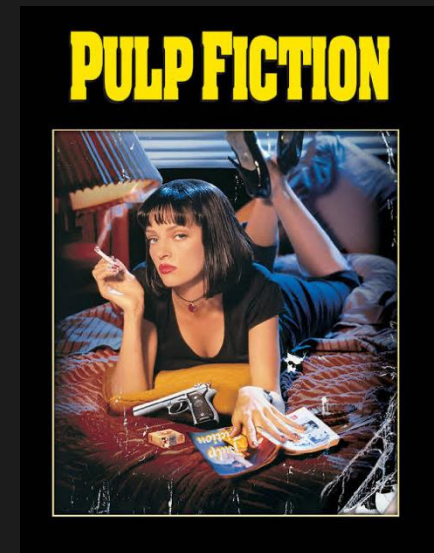
Viewers reconstruct the story from the plot.

**Story** = presumed and inferred events + explicitly presented events

**Plot** = explicitly presented events + added non-diegetic elements

For instance. moody music, credits, intertitles, voice over are elements of **plot NOT story**

Let's take *Pulp Fiction* as an example. The story is the chronological sequence of events involving Jules, Vincent, and other characters. However, the plot rearranges these events into a non-linear structure, creating suspense and thematic connections."



Formally, we turn to week 4's content :“Narrative”

**Narrative** is a fundamental way that humans make sense of the world.

We can consider a *narrative* to be *a chain of events linked by cause and effect and occurring in time and space.*

1. Typically, a narrative begins with one situation;
2. a series of changes occurs according to a pattern of cause and effect;
3. finally, a new situation arises that brings about the end of the narrative.

最重点的来了

Our engagement with the story depends on our understanding of *the pattern of change and stability, cause and effect, time and space.* Narrative is not simply a story.

**Narration** (the plot's way of distributing story information) is the mechanism through which a story is communicated to an audience. It involves choices about who tells the story, how it is told, and the perspective from which it is presented. Whether in literature, film, or other storytelling mediums, narration shapes the audience's understanding and emotional engagement with the narrative. It is a powerful tool for conveying meaning, creating atmosphere, and guiding interpretation.

Including:

1. Narrator (first-person, third-person, unreliable)
2. POV (the perspective from which the story is told), first-person POV.
3. Narrative voice (The tone, style, and personality of the narrator)
4. The temporal structure of events in time.

**Narrative structure** refers to the framework or organization of the story. It is the way the story is arranged or constructed, including the sequence of events, pacing, and the relationship between different parts of the story. **Film narrative** is about the story content—what happens and how it is conveyed.

- You would use film narrative when discussing the story itself, its themes, characters, or how the filmmaker conveys meaning.
- You would use narrative structure when analyzing the organization of the story, such as its pacing, sequence, or the use of structural techniques like flashbacks or parallel storytelling.

Bordwell distinguishes two main types.

**Restricted narration**

Viewer knows only what a character knows.  
detective films.

**Unrestricted narration**

Viewer knows more than the characters.  
classical Hollywood suspense.

## Point of View (POV):

Point of view refers to the perspective from which the narrative is presented. In Bordwell's framework, POV belongs mainly to narration, not just cinematography. Bordwell and Thompson identify two main types:

- **Perceptual POV (seeing what character sees):** This is the visual or auditory perspective of a character. For example, in *The Diving Bell and the Butterfly*, we see the world through the paralyzed protagonist's eyes.
- **Mental POV (access to character thoughts):** This gives us access to a character's thoughts or feelings, often through voice-over narration or subjective imagery. For instance, in *Fight Club*, the protagonist's mental state is revealed through his unreliable narration and hallucinations."

POV shot is more specific, often referring to the visual or experiential viewpoint of a character or the camera.



This refers specifically to the **narrator's viewpoint** and how they present the story. The narrator's perspective can influence the audience's understanding of events.

### Types of Narrators:

- **First-Person Narrator:** The narrator is a character in the story (e.g., *Fight Club*).
- **Third-Person Narrator:** The narrator is outside the story and may be omniscient or limited in their knowledge (e.g., *The Lord of the Rings*).
- **Unreliable Narrator:** The narrator's perspective is flawed or biased, leading to a distorted version of events (e.g., *Gone Girl*).

**In Film:** The narrator's perspective is often conveyed through **voice-over narration** or **visual cues**. For example, in *Forrest Gump*, Forrest's narration provides his unique perspective on the events of his life.

Russian Formalism, a school of literary criticism that emerged in Russia in the early 20th century, had a significant impact on the study of narrative and storytelling. The Formalists were primarily interested in the **form** and **structure** of literary works, rather than their content or social context. They sought to understand how literature works as a system of devices and techniques, and this approach extended to their understanding of narrative. One of the key concepts in Russian Formalism related to narrative is **syuzhet** (also spelled *syzhut* or *sjuzet*), which contrasts with **fabula**.

### 1. Fabula:

- **Definition:** The *fabula* refers to the raw material of the story—the events in their chronological, cause-and-effect order, as they would have happened in "real life."
- **Focus:** It is the basic "what happens" of the narrative, abstracted from the way it is told.
- **Example:** In a crime story, the *fabula* would include the sequence of events: the planning of the crime, the crime itself, the investigation, and the resolution.

### 2. Syuzhet:

- **Definition:** The *syuzhet* refers to the way the story is organized and presented to the audience—the arrangement of events, the pacing, the point of view, and the narrative techniques used.
- **Focus:** It is the "how" of storytelling, emphasizing the artistic manipulation of the *fabula* to create meaning, suspense, or emotional impact.
- **Example:** In the same crime story, the *syuzhet* might begin with the investigation, then use flashbacks to reveal the planning and execution of the crime, creating suspense and engaging the audience.



*Rashomon* (Japanese: 羅生門, Hepburn: Rashōmon) is a 1950 Japanese jidaigeki film directed by Akira Kurosawa

Brimming with action while incisively examining the nature of truth, "Rashomon" is perhaps the finest film ever to investigate the philosophy of justice. Through an ingenious use of camera and flashbacks, Kurosawa reveals the complexities of human nature as four people recount different versions of the story of a man's murder and the rape of his wife.

Each narrator provides a unique perspective on the same event, creating a complex and layered story that challenges the idea of objective truth.

### **Multiple Narrators in *Rashomon***

The film presents the same event—the murder of a samurai and the assault of his wife—through the perspectives of four different narrators:

1. The Bandit (Tajōmaru)
2. The Wife (Masago)
3. The Samurai (through a medium)
4. The Woodcutter

Each narrator provides a distinct version of the events, and their accounts contradict one another in significant ways. This structure is known as **multiple narrators or multi-perspective narration**.

An **unreliable narrator** is a narrator whose credibility is compromised, either because they are lying, misremembering, or have a biased perspective. In *Rashomon*, all four narrators are unreliable to some degree, as their accounts are shaped by their personal interests and emotions.

We make sense of a narrative, then, by identifying its events and linking them by cause and effect, time, and space.

Partly because of our filmmaking decisions

Partly because we need to consider our spectator's reaction to the narrative structure.

Narrative:

it's not simply about telling one story; you can also tell stories in groups.



Why Women Kill is the story of three women living in the same house, but in three different eras. Each of these women is navigating infidelity in their marriages in different ways, which are defined by the time period in which we live. Our boundaries and obstacles are all very era-specific.

## Sequels and prequels: cliffhangers

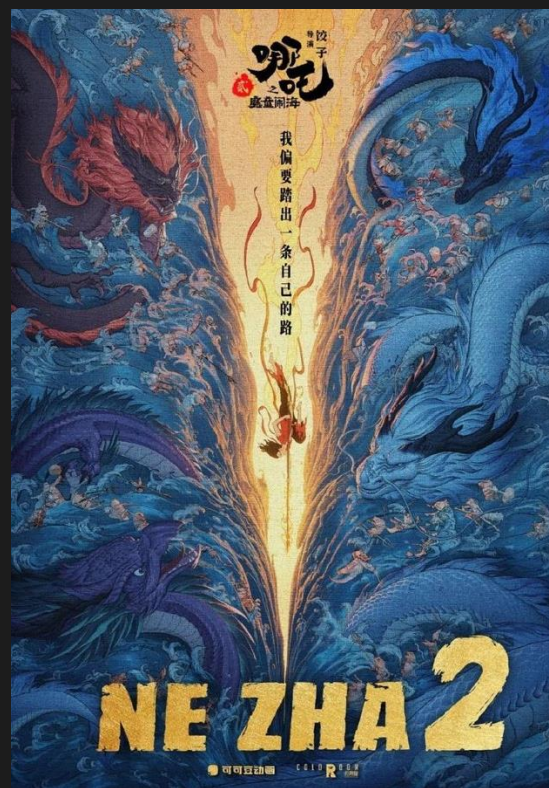
Sequels: They ensure the story continues to evolve, keeping audiences invested in the characters and conflicts.

Prequels: They create a sense of inevitability and connection to the original story, enriching the overall narrative.

Cliffhangers are a powerful storytelling tool, especially in the context of sequels and prequels.

1. Cliffhangers leave audiences with unresolved questions or unresolved tension, which keeps them emotionally invested in the story. This anticipation encourages viewers or readers to return for the next installment to find out what happens next.
2. From a business perspective, cliffhangers are effective in ensuring that audiences return for sequels or prequels, which can boost box office sales, book sales, or streaming numbers. They create a sense of urgency and necessity to continue the story.
3. Cliffhangers can introduce new conflicts, villains, or challenges that will drive the plot of the sequel or prequel. This ensures that the story has a clear direction and purpose moving forward.





Film's conclusion/closing sequence



*The Avengers* series uses cliffhangers masterfully to build anticipation, connect films, and keep audiences engaged across a decade-long saga. These moments are key to the MCU's success, transforming it into a cultural phenomenon.

Marvel cinematic universe

## *Avengers: Infinity War* (2018) – The Snap

•**Cliffhanger:** Thanos succeeds in his mission, snapping his fingers and wiping out half of all life in the universe. The film ends with many beloved heroes disintegrating, leaving the remaining Avengers in shock and despair.

•**Why It Works:**

- It's one of the most shocking and emotional cliffhangers in cinematic history, leaving audiences devastated and desperate to see how the story resolves.
- It creates immediate demand for *Avengers: Endgame*, as fans want to see if the Snap can be undone and how the Avengers will fight back.
- It raises the stakes to an unprecedented level, making the next film feel essential.



## serialised narrative structure



*Naruto* follows a **serialised narrative structure**, typical of many long-running anime and TV series. This structure is episodic yet interconnected, with a mix of **arc-based storytelling** and **overarching plotlines**. The series can be divided into three main parts:

1. **The Original *Naruto* Series:** Focuses on Naruto's early years as a ninja.
2. ***Naruto Shippuden*:** Covers Naruto's teenage years and the larger conflicts in the ninja world.
3. **Filler Arcs:** Non-canon episodes that expand on the world but do not advance the main plot.



•**Story:** The complete chronological sequence of events in the *Naruto* universe, including backstories, character origins, and off-screen events. For example, the story includes the history of the Nine-Tails attack on Konoha, which happened before the series begins.

•**Plot:** The arrangement of these events as presented in the anime. The plot often uses **flashbacks** and **parallel storytelling** to reveal key information. For instance, the backstory of Itachi Uchiha is revealed gradually through flashbacks in *Naruto Shippuden*.

**Filler episodes** are a common feature in long-running anime series

These episodes serve several purposes, but they do not advance the main plot or contribute to the overarching story.

Filler episodes（填充集/原创集）是指在电视节目或动画中，不基于原作（如漫画、小说）内容，由制作组原创的支线故事。

**Filler episodes** are standalone or episodic content that is not adapted from the original manga or source material. They are created by the anime production team to give the manga time to progress ahead of the anime, preventing the anime from catching up to or overtaking the manga.

In the context of *Naruto*, filler episodes often feature original stories, side quests, or comedic moments that are not part of Masashi Kishimoto's manga.



## *Naruto: Shippuden*

Fillers often focus on secondary or underdeveloped characters, giving them more screen time and backstory. For example, in *Naruto*, fillers sometimes focus on characters like Rock Lee or Hinata.

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260 271 279-281 284-295 303-320 347-361 376-377 388-  
390 394-413 416-417 422-423 427-450 464-468 480-483



If you want to perform a detailed analysis of films, normally you need to attend to

Cinematic forms and the narrative structure

(visual patterns and textual qualities of films)

Although we are simply talking about narrative here,  
You need to remember we are engaging with audio-visual medium.

OKAY, here are some further notes:

narrative form or narrative structure? How to use the term.

In fact, the difference between “narrative structure” and “narrative form” reflects two slightly different intellectual traditions in film theory and narratology. David Bordwell indeed prefers the term “narrative form,” and this preference is not accidental but methodological.

In Film Art, Bordwell frames narrative primarily as a **formal system**, not simply as a structure or template. He writes that films embody “narrative form”, emphasising how storytelling functions as a pattern of relationships within the whole film. This means that narrative is treated as one dimension of cinematic form, alongside: visual style, editing, sound, mise-en-scène

So when Bordwell uses narrative form, he wants to stress that narrative is part of the overall formal organisation of the film. In other words:

**Narrative form = how storytelling operates as a formal system within the film.**

“narrative structure” is more common in genre discussions

When scholars talk about genre, they often use “narrative structure” because they are referring to recurring storytelling patterns. We can say: the three-act structure of Hollywood cinema, the quest structure of the adventure film, the investigation structure of the detective film, the romantic union structure of the romantic comedy

Here, the focus is not the entire formal system of the film but rather the pattern of events in the story.

Thus, in genre studies, we mean :narrative structure = recurring arrangement of events typical of a genre

the horror film: threat → investigation → confrontation → survival or death

the detective film: crime (someone died) → investigation → the reconstruction of the past → revelation

the western: arrival → conflict → showdown

## No. 1: Cause and Effect

If narrative depends on changes created by cause and effect, what kinds of things can function as causes? Most often, characters. By triggering events and reacting to them, characters play causal roles within the film's narrative form.

So, characters as causes.

(multiple) protagonist, antagonist, leading/main characters, extras, minor characters.

Stock characters: A stock character is a fictional character based on common social or literary stereotypes. Stock characters are based on clichés and social prejudices. For example, the dumb blonde, the mean stepmother, the loyal servant, the abusive boyfriend, or the evil dictator or CEO

## No. 2: Time

Causes and their effects are basic to narrative, but they take place in time. Our story–plot distinction helps us to understand how filmmakers use narrative form to manipulate time.

As we watch a film, we construct story time on the basis of what the plot presents.

Even if events are shown in chronological order, most plots don't show every detail from beginning to end. We assume that the characters spend uneventful time sleeping, eating, traveling, and so forth, so the periods containing such irrelevant action can be skipped over so **story duration** can be manipulated.

filmmakers must decide how the film's plot will treat

### 1. chronological order :

Filmmakers can choose to present events out of story order.

### 2. temporal duration

In general, a film's plot selects only certain stretches of story duration.

You need to decide – how long does an event last

### 3. frequency.

Most commonly, a story event is presented only once in the plot. Occasionally, however, a single story event may appear twice or even more in the plot treatment.

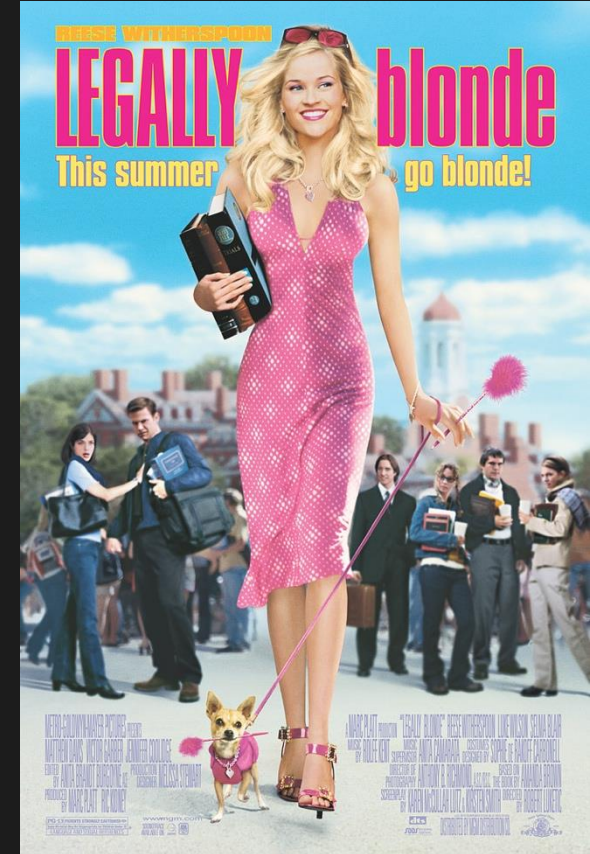




"I'll show you how valuable Elle Woods can be!"

Montage, compressing time.

So, story duration, plot duration, screen duration



### Screen Time:

Screen time refers to the actual running time of the film. For example, *The Lord of the Rings: The Return of the King* has a screen time of approximately 201 minutes."

### Duration Time:

Duration time refers to the time span covered by the story. This can vary widely. For example, *Boyhood* covers 12 years of story time, while *High Noon* takes place in real-time, with the story duration matching the screen time."

### Plot Time:

Plot time refers to the way time is manipulated within the plot. This includes techniques like flashbacks, flash-forwards, and ellipses. For example, in *Memento*, the plot time is non-linear, with scenes alternating between forward and backward progression."



Let's compare *The Godfather* and *Pulp Fiction*.

In *The Godfather*, the plot time spans several decades, but the screen time is just under 3 hours. In *Pulp Fiction*, the plot time is fragmented, with events presented out of chronological order, creating a unique narrative experience.

### No. 3 Space

Normally, the locale of the story action is also that of the plot, but sometimes the plot leads us to imagine story spaces that are never shown.

Story place.

Plot place

And screen place: p.85-86. visible space within the frame. [this is the most important aspect for films]

# Openings, Closings, and Patterns of Development

**Openings:** A film does not just start, it *begins*. The opening provides a basis for what is to come and initiates us into the narrative. It raises our expectations by setting up a specific range of possible causes for what we see. Indeed, the first quarter or so of a film's plot is sometimes referred to as the *setup*.

Very often, the film begins by telling us about the characters and their situations before any major actions occur.

In either case, some of the actions that took place before the plot started—often called the **backstory**—will be stated or suggested so that we can understand what's coming later. The portion of the plot that lays out the backstory and the initial situation is called **the exposition**.



**Development Sections** As a film's plot proceeds, the causes and effects create patterns of development.

### **Character-Based Narratives:**

"In character-based narratives, the focus is on the internal development of characters. The plot is driven by their emotions, relationships, and personal growth. For example, in *The Florida Project*, the narrative revolves around the experiences and perspectives of the child protagonist, Moonee, rather than a series of dramatic events. This aligns with what some scholars call 'character-driven' storytelling."

### **Event-Driven Narratives**

•  
"In contrast, event-driven narratives prioritize external actions and plot twists. The story is propelled by a sequence of events, often with a clear cause-and-effect structure. For example, in *Inception*, the narrative is driven by the heist-like mission and its escalating complications. This aligns with classical Hollywood narrative structure, as discussed by Bordwell and Thompson."

### **Goal-oriented plot**

Another common pattern of development is the goal-oriented plot, in which a character takes steps to achieve an object or condition.

A character arc is the transformation or inner journey of a character over the course of a story. If a story has a character arc, the character begins as one sort of person and gradually transforms into a different sort of person in response to changing developments in the story.

Examples:

The so-called “coming-of-age” films: identity, questions of intimacy, and sexual awakenings.

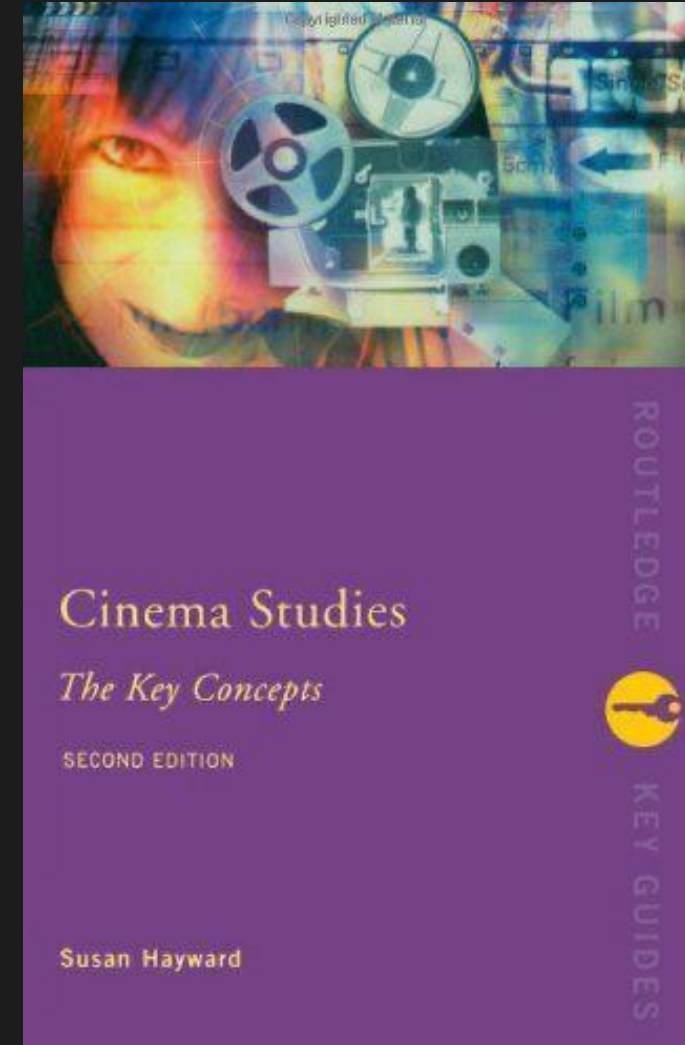


Narrative involves the recounting of real or fictitious events.

**Narrative cinema's** function is storytelling not description, which is, supposedly, a part function of the documentary.

**Narrative** refers to the strategies, codes and conventions (including mise-en-scène and lighting) employed to organize a story.

Primarily, narrative cinema is one that uses these strategies as a means of reproducing the 'real' world, one which the spectator can either identify with or consider to be within the realms of possibility.



Narrative structure is a literary element generally described as the structural framework that underlies the order and manner in which a narrative is presented to a reader, listener, or viewer.

The narrative structures are the plot and the setting.



Other narrative structures you might need to know

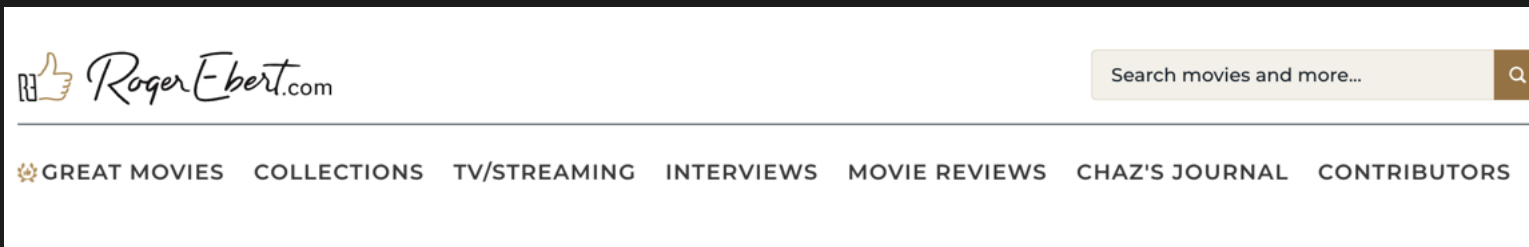
## Screening and example:



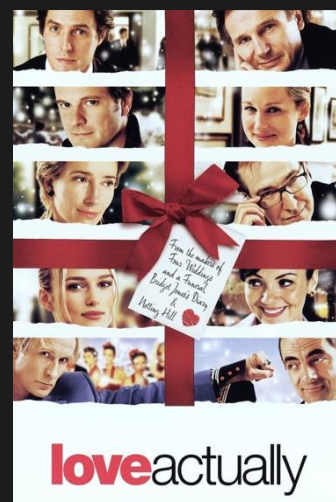
Contagion is a 2011 American medical thriller film directed by Steven Soderbergh.

Its ensemble cast includes Matt Damon, Laurence Fishburne, Elliott Gould, Jude Law, Gwyneth Paltrow, Kate Winslet, Bryan Cranston, Jennifer Ehle, Sanaa Lathan, and Marion Cotillard.

The plot concerns the spread of a highly contagious virus transmitted by respiratory droplets and fomites, attempts by medical researchers and public health officials to identify and contain the disease, the loss of social order as the virus turns into a worldwide pandemic, and the introduction of a vaccine to halt its spread.



Roger Ebert has called “[hyperlink cinema](#),” a form that emerging directors like Alexandro Gonzáles Iñárritu have used to connect narratives set in widely disparate locations (the film *Babel* can be a case in point here).

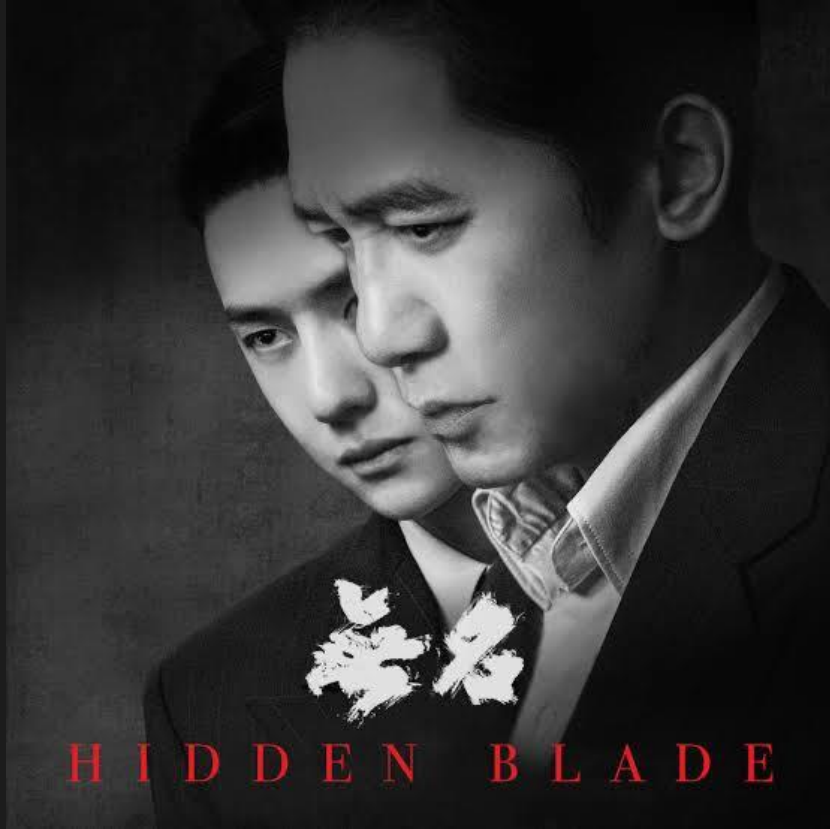


Hyperlink cinema reflects the complexity and interconnectedness of contemporary life. By presenting multiple perspectives and storylines, it encourages audiences to see the bigger picture and consider how individual lives are part of a larger web of relationships and events. This style of filmmaking also challenges traditional narrative structures, offering a more fragmented and layered approach to storytelling that mirrors the way we experience the modern world.

The term “hyperlink cinema” was popularized by film critic **Roger Ebert**, who used it to describe films like *Syriana* (2005) and *Crash* (2004). However, the style has roots in earlier films, such as Robert Altman’s *Nashville* (1975) and *Short Cuts* (1993), which also feature ensemble casts and interwoven narratives. Hyperlink cinema gained prominence in the late 1990s and early 2000s, reflecting the increasing globalization and interconnectedness of the modern world, as well as the rise of the internet and digital communication.

### Characteristics

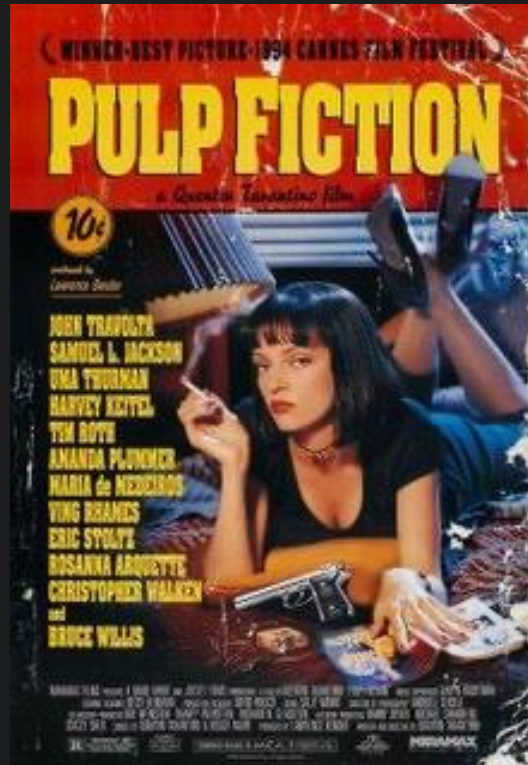
1. **Multiple Storylines:** The film follows several distinct but interconnected narratives, often involving a large ensemble cast.
2. **Interconnectedness:** The characters or storylines are linked in some way, whether through a shared event, location, theme, or coincidence.
3. **Global or Diverse Settings:** Hyperlink cinema often explores stories across different geographic, cultural, or social contexts, emphasizing the interconnectedness of the modern world.
4. **Thematic Unity:** While the stories may seem separate, they are usually tied together by overarching themes, such as love, fate, globalization, or human connection.



### Non-linear Narrative:

1. Scholars often emphasize the film's departure from traditional linear storytelling. Instead of presenting events in chronological order, Tarantino rearranges them to create suspense, irony, and thematic resonance.
2. This non-linear approach challenges the audience to piece together the story, making the viewing experience more engaging and interactive.





The narrative structure of *Pulp Fiction* (1994), directed by Quentin Tarantino, is one of its most distinctive and celebrated features. Scholars and film critics have extensively analyzed its structure, often describing it as **non-linear, fragmented, or episodic**.

The film begins and ends with the same scene: the diner robbery. This creates a sense of circularity, as the final scene chronologically occurs before many of the events in the middle of the film. This circular structure reinforces the idea of interconnectedness and fate.